try to suppress *any and all* publicity about our time machine research. A sensational splash in the press might brand our research as crazy in the eyes of many physicists, and I wanted our paper to be studied seriously by the physics community. The public relations staff acquiesced.

Our paper was published, and all went well. As I had hoped, the press missed it, but among physicists it generated interest and controversy. Letters trickled in, asking questions and challenging our claims; but we had done our homework. We had answers.

My friends' reactions were mixed. Richard Price continued to worry; he had decided I wasn't crazy or senile, but he feared I would sully my reputation. My Russian friend Igor Novikov, by contrast, was ecstatic. Telephoning from Santa Cruz, California, where he was visiting, Novikov said, "I'm so happy, Kip! You have broken the barrier. If *you* can publish research on time machines, then so can *I!*" And he proceeded to do so, forthwith.

The Matricide Paradox

Among the controversies stirred up by our paper, the most vigorous was over what I like to call the *matricide paradox*[10]: If I have a time machine (wormhole-based or otherwise), I should be able to use it to go back in time and kill my mother before I was conceived, thereby preventing myself from being born and killing my mother.[11]

Central to the matricide paradox is the issue of *free will:* Do I, or do I not, as a human being, have the power to determine my own fate? Can I *really* kill my mother, after going backward in time, or (as in so many science fiction stories) will something inevitably stay my hand as I try to stab her in her sleep?

Now, even in a universe without time machines, free will is a terribly difficult thing for physicists to deal with. We usually try to avoid it. It just confuses issues that otherwise might be lucid. With time machines, all the more so. Accordingly, before publishing our paper (but after long discussions with our Milwaukee colleagues), Morris, Yurtsever, and I decided to avoid entirely the issue of free will. We insisted on not discussing at all, in print, human beings who go through a wormhole-based